

don't push further. I'll switch to batting or fitness work. Otherwise, you can overdo it — bowling 70 or 80 overs in practice just chasing a 'feel' that never comes. You might already have bowled enough but still feel unsatisfied.

T20 cricket is heavily driven by data now. In the IPL, you get all kinds of numbers — match-ups, sweeps, reverse sweeps, speeds. Has that trickled into the TNPL as well, or is it more about instinct and gut feel?

It's a merger of both. Gujarat Titans is a good example — they don't rely only on data. Personally, I enjoy data; I like watching videos. But I'd say the best balance is 30 per cent data, 70 per cent instinct.

In TNPL, it's mostly instinct. You've already seen most of the players over the years, and unlike IPL, you don't have Hawk-Eye or detailed numbers on speeds and deviations. So gut feel becomes more important.

And for you personally?

I used to depend a lot on data. Now, not so much. Because on a given day, anything can happen. Say, Suryakumar Yadav — the data shows he's strong over covers or that he sweeps a lot. But there could be a day when he doesn't sweep at all. If you're fixated on the data, you'll keep waiting for something that never comes. It blocks you.

Any examples where data helped you, or where it worked against you?

Plenty. Data helps calm you because it gives you a sense of control — you know a batter's weaknesses. But ultimately, you still need to execute. If you don't land the ball where you're supposed to, the data means nothing. This season, I realised my instinct is powerful. Whenever I backed it, it worked better.

Take Nicholas Pooran. He's probably the best player of spin right now. In the first game against him, I let the data mess with me. In the second game, yes, he hit me for a six

and a four, but I trusted my instinct and came back strong. That was satisfying.

You sound like a collaborative leader by instinct. But were there moments where you had to be the disciplinarian — step in and say, this is the way we're doing it?

Yes, especially in my first full season as captain in 2023–24, when we made the semifinals. That team suited a more directive style. Tamil Nadu as a side has often thrived under that kind of leadership — Dinesh Karthik led like that, and it worked.

There was one game against Karnataka in Chennai where they took a 150-run lead. We had to decide: do we play it safe for one point, or do we chase 330 and go for an outright win? I wasn't dictatorial, but I was clear. I told the team,

"Let's go for it. If we lose, fine, but let's not leave it here. Let's put pressure on them." That was a moment where I had to be decisive, and it brought everyone together.

Tamil Nadu last won the Ranji Trophy in 1987–88. It's been a long time. What do you think this comes down to?

You can point to many things, but if I had to reduce it to one, it would be oneness within the team. All teams that have punched above their weight — India in the 1983 World Cup, in 2007 T20 — had that togetherness. They believed they were stronger as a unit than as individuals.

Tamil Nadu has thrived whenever we've had that spirit. In 2016–17, we won both the Vijay Hazare and the Deodhar. It was a very young team.

Apart from DK, no big India names. Just Vijay Shankar, Washi (Washington Sundar), myself, Aparajith, Indrajith, Aswin Crist, Kaushik Gandhi — all youngsters. What made the difference was that sense of unity. If we can recreate that, where every player believes the team's success matters more than individual milestones, Tamil Nadu will win. If Tamil Nadu wins the Ranji Trophy, individuals will naturally get picked for India.

In recent years, Indian batters have been criticised for struggling against spin, even at home. Has the standard of playing spin in domestic cricket declined?

The standard of playing spin without risk has come down. Counter-attacking is still there, and players are more comfortable with it

« **When you play six months of T20 cricket, singles lose their value. They're useful, yes, but they're not 'gold'. The real currency is fours and sixes** »
— Sai Kishore »



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